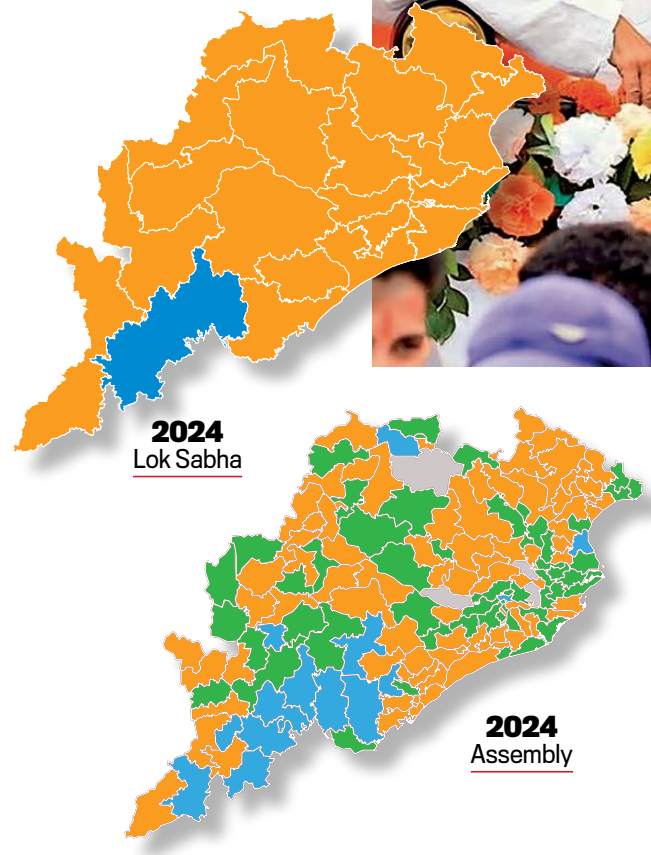
A NEW KING FOR KALINGA

As the BJP prepares to assume Odisha's reins, ending Naveen Patnaik's 24-year reign, it needs to demonstrate how it plans to improve governance and accelerate development

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**





On June 6, two days after Odisha dealt a shocking defeat to the Biju Janata Dal (BJD), ending Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik's 24-year rule, chief secretary Pradeep Jena released a video message assuring the state's people about the continuance of the outgoing government's flagship health scheme, the Biju Swasthya Kalyan Yojana (BSKY). Jena was forced to come up with the clarification following media reports that several hospitals refused to honour the BSKY cards, turning away patients. This sense of uncertainty, believe experts, is likely to be the primary challenge that the incoming BJP government will have to tackle as it starts off. The burning question on everyone's lips is whether it will uphold the welfare initiatives pioneered by Naveen. This intrigue is fuelled by the hints dropped by various state BJP leaders, including their president Manmohan Samal, suggesting a potential adoption of the central Ayushman Bharat health scheme at the state level.

"BJP leaders have not categorically said that they will stop the BSKY. However, people are afraid that this may happen if Ayushman Bharat is implemented. Many hospitals have stopped accepting the card," says Sandeep Sahu, an independent political analyst. On June 5, Samal, who unsuccessfully contested the Chandabali assembly seat, told the media that Ayushman Bharat is a populist scheme and will be implemented so that the 15 million Odias staying outside the state can also avail of its benefits.

The BJP won 78 seats, only four more than the halfway mark, in the 147-member state legislative assembly, while the BJD was reduced to 51, in the hotly contested simultaneous four-phase polls that also decided the fate of the state's 21 Lok Sabha seats. In 2019, the BJD had won 112 assembly seats compared to the BJP's 23. While the BJP's vote share rose to 40 per cent from 32.5 per cent, that of the BJD went down to 40.2 per cent from 42.8 per cent. The Congress bagged 14 seats in the assembly, five more than its 2019 tally. In the case of parliamentary polls, the saffron camp completely routed the BJD by cornering 20 seats with a vote share of 45.4 per cent. The remaining one went to the Congress, while the BJD drew a blank despite securing 37.5 per cent of the votes.

Samal says the BJP will deliver on all the promises it has made. "Be it the issue of opening of Ratna Bhandar